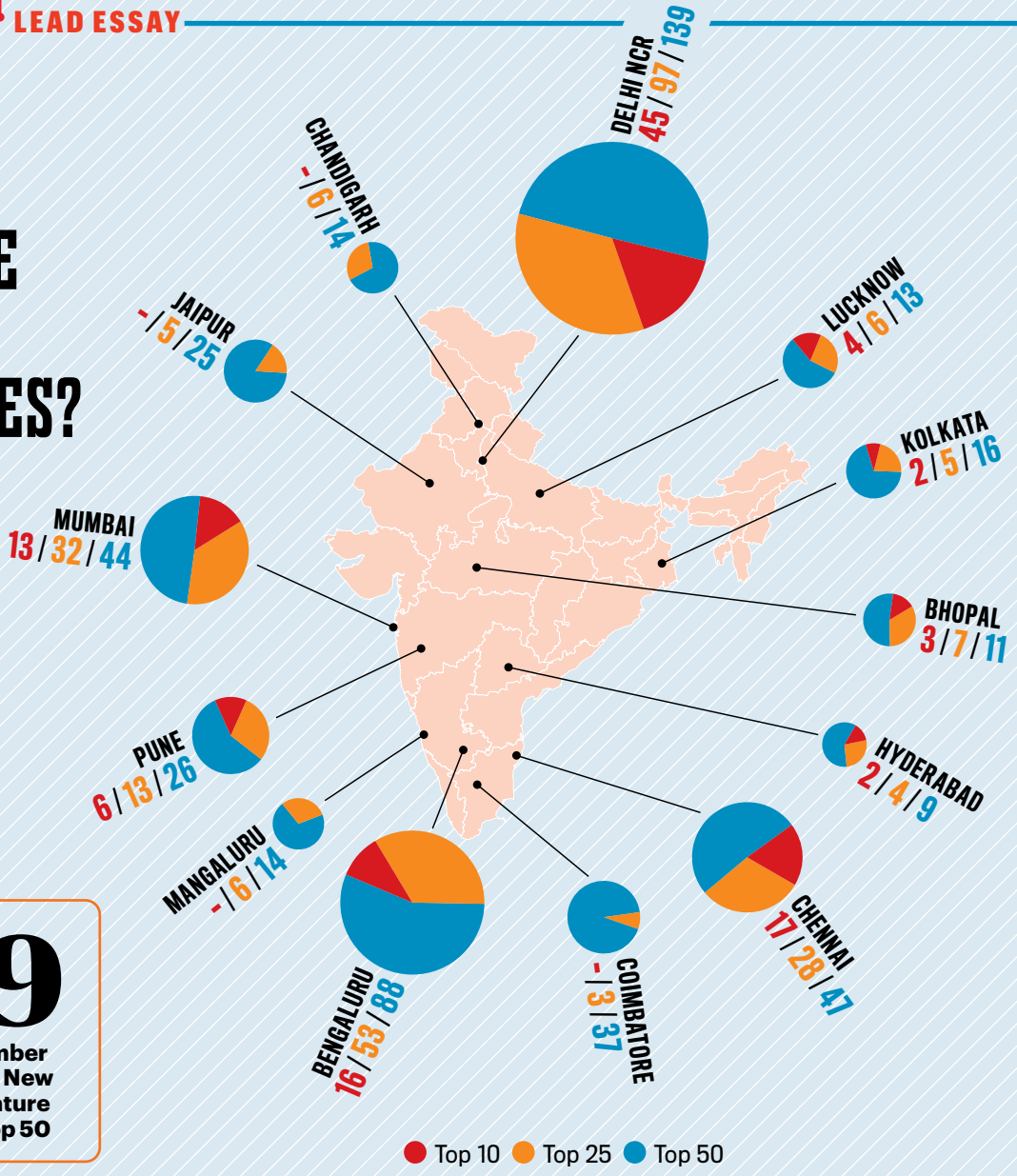
WHERE ARE THE BEST COLLEGES?

The cities that have the maximum number of colleges among the top 10, top 25 and top 50



139

The total number of colleges in New Delhi that feature among the top 50

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

India's higher education ecosystem remains uneven, with stark contrasts between the long-established and the emerging colleges, between urban centres and smaller towns.

If there is one marker on which there is marked progress, it is in terms of global visibility. Over the past decade, India has recorded a 286 per cent increase in the number of institutions featured in global university rankings—reportedly the highest among G20 nations. In the QS World University Rankings: Asia 2026, India tops the continent with the most institutions (163) in the rankings; four Indian universities now feature in the Top 100.

But this international acclaim does not reflect the imbalance that lurks underneath. While India's top five institutions saw their average rank improve significantly—from 224 in the 2024 global QS rankings to 173 in the 2026 edition—the broader picture is less reassuring. Among the 54 Indian universities that feature in the global list, the average rank still hovers at a modest 452. This stark contrast underscores a critical point: the stellar performance of a few institutions risks obscuring

1.3 mn

Research papers India published between 2017 and 2022. The highest number after China, the US and UK

54%

Growth in India's research output in terms of academic papers between 2017 and 2022